



FACT FILE

Karen Chin found small, fossilized burrows in the coprolites of plant-eating dinosaurs. With this evidence, she discovered that dung beetles were clearing dung in the age of the dinosaurs, just as they do today.



▲ DUNG BEETLE with dung ball.

One of the biggest

The huge coprolite below was found to contain chewed bits of bone from a cow-sized meat-eating dinosaur. It's thought to have been a *Tyrannosaurus*'s dropping and measures 15 inches (38 cm) in length, although fragments found nearby suggest it was originally larger. Few dinosaur coprolites are preserved exactly as they were formed, and it's tricky to link them to a particular dinosaur.



▲ FRAGMENTS of bone found in this *Tyrannosaurus* coprolite show that the predator swallowed bones as well as flesh.

It's a dropping!

The fossil hunter Mary Anning (see pages 110–111) found stones in the belly region of the fossils she uncovered and described them as containing fossilized fish bones. Based on her finds, scientist William Buckland gave them the Greek name *coprolites*, meaning “dung stones.”

